

COLOR MIXING



WHEN YOU DECIDE to paint with a particular color, you have a choice of how you mix it and apply it to a painting surface.

There are two principle ways of mixing colors. Firstly, you can mix together one color with another physically on a palette (*see below*), but you should always add small touches of the darker color to the lighter one so that you do not make more of the mixture

than you need. A positive feature of oil paint is that the color you mix and apply wet has the same tone when it dries. Secondly, you can overlay one color onto another. A thin film of transparent red paint over a dry layer of yellow will give an orange color that looks quite different from a physically mixed orange. Another method of color mixing is to place small dots of pure color side by side. These appear to combine “optically,” or visually, in the viewer’s eye so that a third color is perceived.

Mixing clean colors

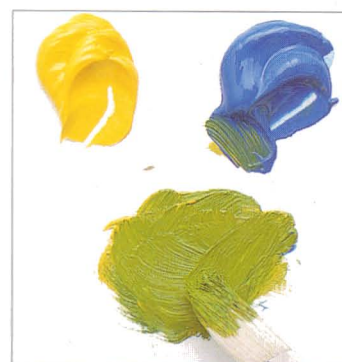
When you mix colors together, always mix them away from other paints on the palette to keep the original colors from becoming sullied. If you physically mix colors (right), use a clean palette knife or brush to transfer color each time. The brush must again be completely clean before you overlay colors (below). You can also mix colors in a “striated” brushstroke with separate colors on a brush (below right). To mix colors optically, gauge the right proportion of one color to another, or you will create something that looks gray. Allow one set of dots to dry before adding a new color.



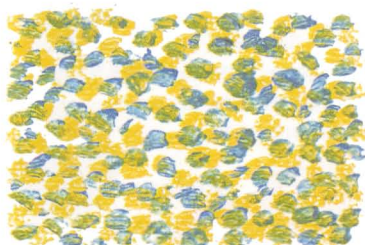
1 ▲ Lay out the colors around the edge of your palette with a good gap between them so that they stay clean. Use a palette knife to transfer color away.



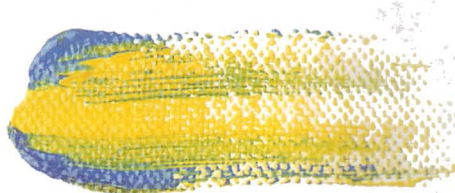
2 ▲ To physically mix green from these two colors, start with the yellow and add small dabs of the stronger blue paint to it as you mix.



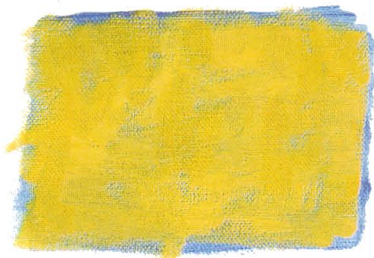
3 ▲ Continue to add touches of blue to the mix until you have the right shade of green. Make sure that both paints are thoroughly mixed together.



Dots of yellow and blue blend visually



A striated brushstroke contains two separate colors that give the impression of a third



Yellow painted stiffly over blue gives a broken green



A thin glaze of yellow over blue appears green

CARE OF PAINTS



Paints are expensive, so it is worth taking care of your materials. Clean excess paint away with a tissue so that the lid screws on firmly. This also protects the strength and purity of a color, which can easily be ruined if the tube is neglected.